worship is of the goddess as Bhadrakali, a form of Kali. One temple in Thiruvananthapuram, the Attukal Bhagavathi temple, is listed in the *Guinness Book of World Records* for the largest gathering of women in one place at one time: millions (2.5 million in 2009, a record that is broken every year, with 4.5 million reported in 2017) assemble each February for the Pongala, at which offerings are cooked and prepared for the goddess.

There is a marvellous Puranic story about the birth of Durga. It is said that a terrible buffalo-headed demon, Mahishasura, had succeeded in conquering all the gods (or *devas*) and established himself as the master of all creation. The gods, despairing in defeat, retreated to a conclave under Lord Indra to find a solution. They decided to pool their strengths, each contributing a particular weapon or personal attribute, and when they had made their contributions and due rituals had been conducted, a dazzling light engulfed the universe from which emerged a fierce female warrior, riding a snarling tiger, wielding a weapon in each of her eighteen arms. She engaged in furious and bloody battle with Mahishasura for nine days and nine nights, at the end of which she vanquished him. These nine days and nights are celebrated annually by Hindus as the nine-day Navaratri festival, which celebrates the defeat of terrible evil by the forces of good—though interestingly, some fringe groups have started to commemorate Mahishasura instead, claiming he is the symbol of the indigenous Adivasis (Tribal peoples) vanquished by the 'civilising' onslaught of the mainstream Hindus.

The various manifestations of Devi suggest that Hinduism took on board multiple goddess-worshipping cults; Kali seems to have been a pre-Vedic goddess converted by the Hindus into one more form of Shakti. Sometimes the same figures in Hindu texts have different genders: Vishnu famously adopted a female form for specific purposes. A female form of Ganesha, now little worshipped, was depicted as Vinayaki or Ganeshvari. In the *Mahabharata*, Arjuna becomes Arjuni (female) and Brihannala (of the third gender) without losing his masculine valour; indeed, the Madurai temple has sculptures of him in all three forms.